James C. E. Zabel

SENIOR PRODUCT DESIGNER · UX LEADER · 15+ YEARS

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PROFILE

Senior product designer at Microsoft, building *AI-powered, agentic experiences* in Azure Advisor. Previously led design across *Azure CXS, Resiliency, and Customer Health*, and scaled an enterprise IoT platform past *20M devices* as the founding designer. AI-native, mission-oriented, still shipping software myself.

SKILLS

LEADERSHIP
Design management, UX research, design ops, mentorship, executive storytelling

CRAFT
Design systems, prototyping, information architecture, data visualization, mobile & enterprise SaaS

AI
Agentic UX, AI-assisted authoring, human-in-the-loop review, Responsible AI

DATA
SQL, data visualization, competitive analysis, NPS & product analytics

TOOLS
Figma, Adobe XD, Sketch, Axure, Zeplin

BUILD
HTML, CSS, TypeScript, React Native, SQL

EDUCATION

M.S. Industrial Engineering
Human Factors Psychology focus
Clemson University · 2010

B.S. Industrial Engineering
Clemson University · 2009

EXPERIENCE

Microsoft / Senior Product Designer — May 2026 – Present

- Lead UX for AI-powered, agentic experiences in **Azure Advisor**, Microsoft's recommendation engine that helps enterprise customers cut cloud cost, reduce risk, and modernize their workloads.
- Design workflows that turn long, generic recommendation lists into prioritized, contextual actions, so customers know what to fix first.
- Helped modernize authoring and governance for a catalog of **~1,700 recommendations**, introducing AI-assisted drafting with human review.
- Partner with platform and engineering teams on AI interaction patterns, accessibility, and Responsible AI; also drive UX for CX Observe, internal customer-health tooling.

Microsoft / Senior Design Manager — Apr 2023 – May 2026

- Managed and coached a multidisciplinary team of **6 designers and UX researchers** across Azure Advisor, CX Observe, and customer-health products.
- Recognized with **Azure X Manager of the Year** for delivery results and people leadership.
- Translated ambiguous, cross-organization priorities into clear product direction and execution plans; influenced roadmap and investment decisions.
- Built alignment across product, engineering, research, and leadership while empowering the team to own major workstreams.

Microsoft / Senior UX Designer — Feb 2022 – Apr 2023

- Led UX for internal Azure field platforms serving **4,000+ users across 10+ Microsoft organizations**.
- Drove **175% monthly-active-user growth** post-launch; supported outcomes tied to **$25M+ projected revenue** and **$3M annual cost savings**.
- Trusted IC partner to senior PM and engineering leaders; contributed to early AI/LLM exploration that shaped later agentic work.

SnapOne (formerly SnapAV) / Lead Data Analyst — 2020 – Feb 2022

- Founding member of SnapOne's data team, turning insights from its **connected IoT platforms** into product strategy.
- Designed and launched data-insight experiences for customers, end customers, and internal stakeholders.
- Team scrum master, prioritizing product-development requests and partnering with PMs to define and refine asks.
- Delivered quarterly executive presentations and competitive analysis that shaped strategy across **all major SnapOne brands**.

EXPERIENCE, CONTINUED

SnapOne (formerly SnapAV) / UX Manager — Feb 2015 – 2020

- Led UX for OvrC, an IoT cloud remote management platform supporting **20M+ managed devices** globally.
- Led OvrC Connect, a residential consumer app for monitoring and controlling smart home devices.
- Provided strategic design support for the **$150M+ Connected Device category**, driving double-digit annual growth.
- Managed onshore and offshore design teams; built a standardized design system across all software interfaces.

SnapOne (formerly SnapAV) / User Experience Engineer — Aug 2013 – Feb 2015

- Early team member helping launch OvrC, a device management platform now supporting **20M+ IoT devices**.
- Led offshore UI team using AngularJS, HTML5, CSS3, Bootstrap, and WebSocket.
- Created wireframes, prototypes, and flowcharts; ran usability studies with clients to iterate design.

Lockheed Martin / Human Systems Integration Engineer — Nov 2011 – Aug 2013

- Principal investigator on usability assessments for the Navy **Ballistic Missile Defense 5.1** program.
- Used iterative design and heuristic evaluations to develop new GUIs introduced to fleet architecture.
- Gathered input from active-duty sailors to resolve novel interface and layout problems.

General Electric (Axiem Engineering) / Human Factors Engineer — 2011

- Risk assessments, Root Cause Analysis, and Preliminary Hazard Assessments supporting new product development across multiple GE business units.
- Identified safety-critical components and systems; completed PHA, HazOp, and Accident Scenario Reviews.

PERSONAL PROJECTS

Products I designed, built, and shipped myself. Full write-ups at jczabel.com/projects.

CharTaker / React · Capacitor · Supabase — 2024 – Present

- Starfinder character manager covering guided character creation, live combat, starships, and real-time shared sessions. Designed, built, and **shipped to the App Store and Google Play**.

MealMapper / React Native · Supabase — 2024 – Present

- Household meal planner that turns a week of meals into a sorted grocery list and a matched Kroger cart, synced live between family members. Rebuilt after testing with friends and family.

Sealed Bid / Next.js · Postgres · Monte Carlo — 2026

- Sealed-bid game that set the draft order for a 14-person fantasy league: secret bids on phones, then a synchronized reveal on the TV. **Ran live on draft night.** Started as King's Bluff, a chess and poker game I balanced with a Monte Carlo simulator.

HONORS & CERTIFICATIONS

- Azure X Manager of the Year
- AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner